Chinese emperors craved for. Time and again war broke out for the possession of these heavenly fast horses. Historian Sima Qian in his chronicles Shiji (Records of the Historian) reports that in BC 103 commander Li Guanli with his army numbering 60,000 warriors sieged Aksikent for forty days blocking the access to the city of drinking water. But there were wells in the fortress and its defenders managed to hold out until the army of a friendly state of Kangju came to the aid of the city.

At the beginning of the first millennium the cities of the Ferghana Valley were conquered first by Kushan rulers, then by Turks. But it was at this time that Aksikent was turned into the economic centre of the state. Numerous trade caravans came here from Kashgar and China, Asia Minor and Byzantium. Locally made fabrics, pottery and metalware were in great demand in the international markets. Aksikent increased its significance after the Ferghana Valley was conquered by the Arabs and the town became the capital city of the area. Antique Aksikent was only two kilometres in perimeter. In the 8^{th}-9^{th} centuries, according to the medieval chronicler and geographer Maqsidi, the town grew into a large township encircled by the 18-kilometer-long outer wall with five gates. The archaeological excavation proved that there was in Aksikent a citadel with a splendid palace and a jail, whereas in shakhristan (inner city) there was a city mosque and bathhouses. On the bank of Syr Darya river there was a big square for Friday praying. In rabat—the trade suburbs of the city which were protected by outer walls and watching towers, there were bazaars and craftsmen workshops. Archeologists found coins minted in Aksikent in the ninth and eleventh centuries.

For five years since 2002 the ruins of antique and pre-Mongol Aksikent were researched by the scientists of the British-Uzbek archaeological expedition led by Professor of College London Institute of archaeology Tilo Rehren. In the urban quarters of craftsmen, the scientists discovered fire-resistant crucibles made of kaolin. Such crucibles could resist the temperature of 1300 degrees. For the smelting furnaces the local metallurgists used natural fuel—the wood of juniper tree which being burnt can provide high temperature. It was a necessary criterion for smelting steel from carboniferous iron ore which the nearby spurs of the Tien Shan mountains are rich in. After masterly hammering such steel became exclusively strong, bendable and had a specific pattern, that is, it became the steel known as ‘Damask steel’. No wonder that in the Arabic chronicles of the 10th century it was mentioned that ‘cold steel from Ferghana was used everywhere from Khorasan to Baghdad’. A British archaeologist suggested that not only ready-made cold steel weapons were imported from Aksikent, but the steel itself was delivered to Damascus